

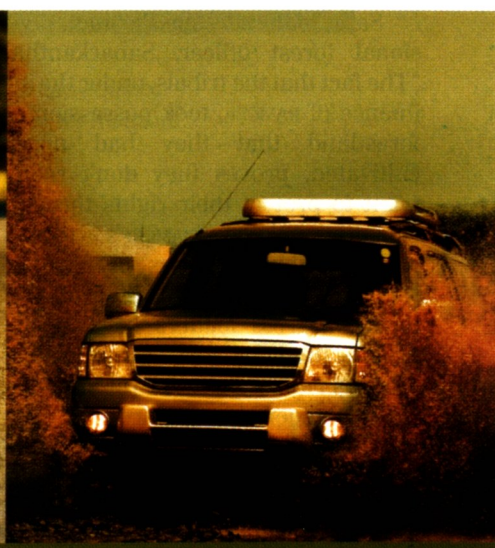
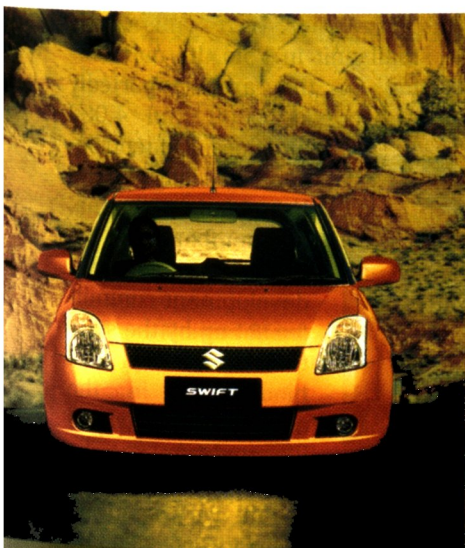
ANGER AND UNREST: Police hold talks with tribals in Jher (left); Madhusudan Mistry (wearing spectacles) at the funeral of a tribal sarpanch of Jher, an affected village. "These activists swear in the name of Babasaheb Ambedkar, take membership money from locals and promise to put them in possession of forestland by saying that it is going to be converted into an SEZ that will be sold to big companies by the Government." BAMCEF's pamphlets about protecting the rights of Mulnivasis talk of "destroying the hidden enemy (read Brahminism) which is bent upon destroying the backward classes". The BAMCEF website censures Brahmins even as it blames the Congress-led UPA Government for its anti-poor policies. It dubs the demand of some politicians for caste-based reservation in the private sector as a conspiracy for withdrawing it from government services.

The anti-Congress rhetoric is somewhat misleading, since the outfit thrives on the sympathy of local party leaders. Forest officials say that local Congress MP Madhusudan Mistry and



MLA Ashwin Kotwal have been lending tacit support to BAMCEF with an eye on the coming Lok Sabha polls. The Congress might want to highlight the issue of the delay in granting land to tribals under the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006, which ensures ownership rights

to forest dwellers over the land they had been cultivating till December 12, 2005. Madhusudan was among the pall-bearers at the funeral of the two tribals killed in police firing. Terming their deaths as "cold-blooded murder" and accusing the police and the state Government of gagging the tribals on the issue of their legitimate rights on



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